SEND WITH THE SCRIPT

Self-recording guide

Reality-TV confessional style: you sit alone and talk to the camera, deadpan. Every script is a self-contained monologue with no interviewer, so you can prop up your own phone and record it in five minutes whenever you have a free moment.

Setup

- **Nobody films you.** Prop your phone horizontal against a stack of books or a mug, at face height, about an arm's length away. Sit in a chair against a plain wall or a bookshelf.
- **Light:** face a window or a lamp. Don't sit with a window behind you.
- **Eyeline:** look just to the side of the lens, as if a producer is sitting next to the phone. Glancing at the lens once or twice is fine.
- **Tone:** deadpan beats hammy. You are a sincere person who has nothing to hide and is slightly annoyed to be asked.

Recording

- **The script:** read it from a second screen or a printout taped just under the phone. The *(beat)* and *(pause)* marks are where the laughs live. Hold them longer than feels natural.
- **Takes:** two max. Send the slightly flubbed one. Don't edit anything.
- **Length:** 60 to 90 seconds. Start recording, wait two seconds, begin. Stop two seconds after the last line.
- **Send it:** text or AirDrop the raw video to the room parent. They add the title card and load it onto the classroom laptop.

The ask (email or text to each suspect)

Subject: 5 minutes of acting for the 4th grade Halloween party?

Hi [Name],

Room 12's Halloween party on Oct 30 is a whodunit, and the kids are going to investigate four staff "suspects." Would you be one of the three who record a statement? All it takes is a 90-second video of yourself that you can record alone on your phone whenever you have a free minute. No one films you, no one edits you, and you don't need to attend the party.

Attached is your script. It's a monologue, so just talk to the camera. Quick tips:
• Phone horizontal, propped at face height, plain wall behind you
• Look just beside the lens, like a producer is sitting there
• Deadpan. Sincere. Slightly annoyed to be asked.
• Hold the pauses. Two takes max. Send me the raw video by Oct 23.

The kids will watch it on the projector during the party and, I promise, lose their minds. Thank you!

[Your name], Room 12 room parent · [phone]

The Custodian gets a different ask: "You're a suspect who declined to comment. That's it. That's the whole job. Please act shifty in the hallway on Oct 30."

VIDEO 1 · PLAYS AFTER STATION 1

VIDEO 1 — THE PRINCIPAL

self-recorded monologue, ~90 sec · The only interview with real information, and it arrives by accident. Deadpan. Hold the beats.

TITLE CARD · INTERVIEW 1 · THE PRINCIPAL · 9:12 AM

(Sit. Look just beside the camera. Check your watch.)

I have a meeting in four minutes, so let's make this quick.

You want to know where I was yesterday at 2:15. I was in a meeting. I'm always in a meeting. Yesterday it was a meeting about the next meeting.

And you want to know what I know about the missing candy. Let me be very clear about this. I have not heard ANYTHING, and I know NOTHING, about anyone stealing the squishies.

(beat)

I mean candy.

(beat)

...Did I say squishies? What was I thinking! Candy. The candy. I know nothing about the candy.

(pause. Straighten your tie or collar.)

I did not say squishies. I may have said squishies. It's a very common word. People say it all the time. In meetings. I am the principal of this school. I say a lot of words every day. Statistically, some of them are going to be "squishies."

(too fast)

And for the record, I have never even seen that jar. The big one. On the high shelf by the window. With the three strips of tape on the lid and the label that says "do not open."

(realize what you just said)

...Which I can only describe because people have described it to me. In meetings.

(pause)

Do I own any squishies myself? I'm the principal.

(beat)

...One. It's a cat. It's on my desk. It's for stress. This is stressful. (look at watch) I'm late.

(Stand up and walk out of frame. Leave the phone recording for 3 more seconds, then say, from off camera, slightly muffled:)

Is it off? Did it get the squishy thing? ...Can we cut the squishy thing?

(Then stop recording.)

VIDEO 2 · PLAYS AFTER STATION 2

VIDEO 2 — THE GYM TEACHER

self-recorded monologue, ~75 sec · Zero information. Genuinely does not understand squishies and is a little offended to be asked.

TITLE CARD · INTERVIEW 2 · THE GYM TEACHER · 11:05 AM

(Sit. Whistle around your neck if you have one. Look just beside the camera. You are missing a dodgeball unit for this.)

I'm missing a dodgeball unit for this, so.

Where was I at 2:15 yesterday? Gym. Where I always am. Inflating things. Deflating things. The cycle of life.

Did I go near Room 12? I go near every room. The hallway is my warm-up lap.

(long sigh)

Okay. Can I say something about these squishies? I don't see what these kids see in squishies anyway. You squeeze it. It goes back. You squeeze it again. It goes back again. That's it. That's the whole thing. I just don't understand the obsession these days.

(beat)

So no, I didn't take that jar. Why would I take a whole jar of something I don't understand? You want to steal something, steal a good jump rope. Those are valuable.

(pause. Look down at your shirt.)

And yes, I'm wearing orange. It's a school color. Half this building is wearing orange. (look back up) Are you writing that down?

(beat)

Last thing. Whoever has those squishies: there's a whole class of kids out there who can run a mile but can't go a day without squeezing a foam avocado. Think about that.

(stand up)

I'm going back to the gym.

(Walk out of frame. Stop recording.)

VIDEO 3 · PLAYS AFTER STATION 3

VIDEO 3 — THE LIBRARIAN

self-recorded monologue, ~75 sec, WHISPERED throughout · Zero information, whispered throughout. Accidentally sounds guilty three times.

TITLE CARD · INTERVIEW 3 · THE LIBRARIAN · 12:30 PM

(Sit. Whisper the entire thing, as if you're still in the library. Look just beside the camera.)

(whispering) I know I don't have to whisper. It's a habit.

Where was I at 2:15 yesterday? Shelving. I shelve from 2:00 to 2:30 every day. Alone. In the back. With no witnesses.

(pause)

That sounded worse than I meant it to.

Did I see anyone near Room 12? I saw someone in the hallway. Moving quickly. Carrying something. Wearing orange.

(beat. Look down at your own clothes.)

...I'm wearing orange.

(pause)

Do I like squishies? I love squishies. I have a squishy on every cart. They're very good for stress. Shelving is stressful. People put books back in the wrong place on purpose.

(beat. Realize how all of that sounded.)

So, to summarize: I had motive, I had access, and I was wearing orange.

(long pause)

I'd like to amend my earlier statements.

(beat)

No. I did not take the squishies. But if I had, they would be alphabetized by now.

(lean in toward the camera, whisper even quieter)

One more thing for the detectives. Whoever took them... check their feet.

(sit back)

I don't know why I said that. I just felt like a detective would say that.

(Stand, push the chair in silently, walk out of frame. Stop recording.)

VIDEO 4 · PLAYS AFTER THE ARREST WARRANTS ARE READ

VIDEO 4 — THE CONFESSION — THE CHIEF

self-recorded monologue, ~90 sec · Starts defensive, cracks fast, ends with the location of the loot.

TITLE CARD · INTERVIEW 4 · THE CHIEF · 1:15 PM · (recorded under protest)

(Sit. Arms crossed. Look just beside the camera. You are offended to be here.)

I want it on the record that I am not a suspect. I'm the Chief. The Chief is never a suspect. That's how it works.

(beat)

Yes, my shoes are a size 10. Lots of people are a size 10.

Yes, I was in the building at 2:15. I'm a teacher. I'm always in the building. I live here, basically.

(look down at your clothes)

Yes, I am wearing orange. ...It's festive.

(pause)

And yes, I heard what the witness said. That the thief squeezed one and whispered "so satisfying."

(very long pause. Quietly:)

It IS satisfying, though.

(beat. Uncross your arms. Exhale.)

Fine. FINE. It was me. I took the jar. And yes, it was squishies. It was always squishies. Do you know why I labeled it "candy"? Because if I had labeled it "squishies," that jar would have lasted eleven minutes. Do you know what it's like to teach a math lesson while twenty squishies get squeezed in rhythm? It sounds like a swamp. A swamp that's learning fractions.

So I didn't steal it. I RELOCATED it. For safekeeping. From myself, mostly.

(wince)

And yes, the Principal knew. He walked in on me. Mid-relocation. Arms full. I gave him the avocado one to keep quiet. Clearly that didn't work. He's terrible at secrets. He said "squishies" in a MEETING once.

(lean in, almost proud)

Where are they now? Somewhere in that room. In plain sight. Hidden the only way a teacher knows how.

(beat)

You'd need a very special light to see them.

(look right into the lens for the first time)

Nice work, detectives. Now go find them.

(beat)

And if anyone squeezes one during math on Monday, I will do it again.

(Reach toward the camera and stop recording.)